drunken antics, we secretly decided to get him drunk. When Gupta said he would not have anything intoxicating, Mani said with a poker face, 'How sad, Gupta. That means you can have only champagne, not whiskey.'

'Why, doesn't champagne give you a high? Now Gupta was curious.

'How silly,' Mani continued. 'Did you see how many champagne bottles we drank at Vernon? It's just the taste.'

With some encouragement from others to not waste an opportunity to taste the elixir from pinot noir in its homeland, Gupta agreed to take a sip. Someone quickly filled a glass with the white sparkling wine and added a dash of whiskey to it before extending it to Gupta. Hesitantly, he took a sip. Then two. And more.

I don't think Gupta was naïve enough to think champagne is only as good as a soft drink, but clearly he did not expect the sleight of hand that infused the whiskey into his wine glass. Gupta was soon flying. While the rest of us laughed and made merry, Gupta was getting increasingly worried about what the alcoholic concoction was doing to him.

'My head is spinning,' Gupta shouted.

'Now, that's what a turbo pump feels like,' someone shouted back.

Everyone was roaring with laughter.

The next day, as we were nursing a hangover, Gupta said he did not remember anything that happened after he had that champagne.

We looked at each other. Then I spoke, 'Are you serious, Gupta?'

'Not a thing.'

'Don't you remember dancing in the lobby?'

'What?'

That was almost a shriek from the modest and taciturn Gupta.

'The dance wasn't bad,' chipped in someone else. 'But people started staring only when you removed the shirt.'

Now Gupta was getting worked up.

'You mean I removed my shirt and danced in the lobby? Hey, c'mon guys, tell me you are kidding.'

Amidst bursts of laughter each one contributed his bit, one saying Gupta removed his trousers too; another wondering why he tried to wear his socks